PA 403: Program Evaluation
Session 2017

Department of Public Administration | Jahangirnagar University

Instructor: Ashraf Haque | Email: haqash.01@gmail.com | Office: SSB 408 | Office Hours: Monday 4:30–5:30 PM. Class: Tuesday 2: 3:30 PM.

Course Description

Programs designed to help people sometimes fail them. And the people running those programs are often the last to know. A school attendance intervention in Dhaka may show impressive numbers while leaving the children it was meant to serve no better off. A disaster relief operation in Patuakhali may reach the communities that are easiest to access rather than the ones most in need. A health program in Rangamati may produce outcomes that look strong in aggregate but mask deep inequalities in who actually benefits. These are not hypothetical failures. They are documented ones. And the discipline that exists to prevent them and to hold programs accountable is program evaluation.

This course asks a deceptively simple question: Do social programs work? Answering it rigorously turns out to require a sophisticated toolkit: logic modeling, qualitative inquiry, statistical methods, research design, and a clear-eyed understanding of the political and ethical environment in which evaluations are conducted. Evidence does not speak for itself. It is produced by people, commissioned by institutions, and used or ignored in contexts shaped by interests and power. A competent evaluator must understand all of this.

By the end of this course, you will not simply know the stages of program evaluation. You will be able to design one, critique one, and make a defensible funding recommendation based on one. You will also understand why those skills are inseparable from questions of ethics, equity, and civic accountability.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

1. **Frame evaluation questions:** identify the stakeholders of a program evaluation, specify the questions the evaluation should answer, and explain the difference between needs assessment, process evaluation, and outcome evaluation.
2. **Build a theory of change:** construct a logic model that maps the causal pathway from program inputs to intended outcomes, and identify the assumptions on which that pathway depends.
3. **Design an evaluation:** select an appropriate evaluation design, experimental, quasi-experimental, or observational, justify the choice given real-world constraints, and anticipate the threats to validity the design must address.
4. **Apply core methods:** implement probability sampling, design valid survey instruments, and interpret the output of causal inference methods, including randomized experiments, regression discontinuity, and difference-in-differences.
5. **Critically appraise evidence:** assess the strengths and limitations of a completed evaluation, identify sources of bias and overstatement, and distinguish between statistical significance and practical significance.

6. **Communicate findings professionally:** write a policy-facing evaluation report and present findings orally to a critical audience, defending recommendations under questioning.
7. **Navigate the politics of evidence:** recognize the ethical obligations of an evaluator, identify when findings are being suppressed or misrepresented, and articulate the evaluator's responsibilities to program participants, funders, and the public.

Teaching Approach

Program evaluation is not an academic exercise. It is a professional practice with real consequences for real people. The programs you will learn to evaluate serve children, patients, prisoners, refugees, and communities in poverty. The decisions made on the basis of evaluation findings affect whether those programs are funded, expanded, reformed, or shut down. I want you to feel the weight of that responsibility from the first week, not just at the end.

That means this course privileges application over coverage. Lecture segments are short and focused. Most of your learning will happen through case analyses, team project work, and structured critique of real evaluations. I will ask you to defend your methodological choices, challenge your assumptions, and engage seriously with the hardest objections to your design decisions. Your classmates will do the same.

I also want this course to ask a question that evaluation textbooks sometimes avoid: whose interests does this evaluation serve? Methods are never neutral. Randomized trials may be the gold standard of causal inference, but they are not always feasible, affordable, or ethical. Surveys can be designed to find what funders want to find. I will consistently ask you to look underneath the methodology at the assumptions and incentives that shaped it.

Signature Assignments

Project 1: Propose a Program Evaluation Design — 25% of Final Grade

Project 1 asks you to do what evaluation professionals do when they respond to a Request for Proposals: read a program description, understand what the funder needs to know, and design an evaluation rigorous enough to answer those questions under real-world constraints of time, budget, and access.

The Task

Your team will select one of three RFPs distributed in Week 1. Each RFP describes a real social program, in health, education, or social welfare, and specifies the evaluation questions the funder wants answered. Your team must produce a written evaluation proposal that does the following:

- Define the program's theory of change using a logic model, identifying the causal pathway from inputs to outcomes and the assumptions it rests on.
- Specify the evaluation design, experimental, quasi-experimental, or observational, and justify the choice given the program's context, the available data, and the ethical constraints.
- Describe the data collection strategy: sampling approach, sample size rationale, survey instruments or qualitative protocols, and how the chosen method addresses the key threats to validity.
- Identify the primary limitations of your proposed design and explain how you would manage or disclose them.

- Address equity: does your design ensure the evaluation reaches and accurately represents all subgroups the program is meant to serve?

Format and Length

The proposal should be 1,500–2,000 words, written as a professional document addressed to the program funder. Use headings. Include a one-paragraph executive summary. Cite your sources. The writing should be clear and direct. Funders do not read academic prose.

Process and Milestones

Teams are assigned in Week 1. In Week 3, you select your RFP and submit a one-paragraph rationale. In Week 5, you submit a draft logic model for instructor feedback. The full written proposal is due at the end of Week 11. Written feedback will be returned within one week.

Evaluation Criteria

- Theory of change: Is the logic model coherent? Are the underlying assumptions made explicit?
- Design justification: Is the chosen design appropriate for the program and context? Is the justification argued, not just asserted?
- Methods quality: Is the sampling strategy sound? Are the instruments or protocols well designed to measure what they claim to measure?
- Limitations and ethics: Are threats to validity acknowledged honestly? Are equity considerations addressed?
- Professional presentation: Is the proposal clear, well-organized, and appropriate for a funder audience?

Project 2: Evaluation as a Decision Tool — 20% of Final Grade

Project 2 asks you to do the other half of what evaluation professionals do: read evaluations that already exist, assess how much you can trust them, and make a defensible funding recommendation based on what they show and what they do not.

The Task

Your team will be assigned two completed program evaluations of the same general type of intervention. Your written report must do the following:

- Appraise the strength of evidence in each evaluation: design quality, measurement validity, sampling adequacy, and the plausibility of the causal claims made.
- Identify the key limitations of each evaluation and assess how seriously those limitations affect the conclusions.
- Compare the two evaluations: do they reach compatible conclusions? If not, why and which do you find more credible?
- Make a specific funding recommendation: should the program be funded, expanded, reformed, or discontinued? Your recommendation must be explicitly grounded in the evidence you have appraised, not in your prior beliefs about the program.
- Identify lessons learned for future evaluations your agency might commission of similar programs.

Format and Length

The report should be 1,200–1,500 words, written as a memo to a hypothetical funding agency director. Be direct and specific. Vague conclusions, for instance, “more research is needed,” will not be accepted as a substitute for a defensible recommendation.

Process and Milestones

Project 2 is assigned at the start of Week 8. Teams present their findings publicly in Week 14 (13–15 minutes each, followed by open questions). The written report is due at the end of Week 14. You are evaluated on both the written report and your performance under oral questioning.

Evaluation Criteria

- Evidence appraisal: Are the evaluations' strengths and limitations assessed with precision and appropriate skepticism?
- Comparative analysis: Does the team engage seriously with the differences between the two evaluations rather than treating them as independent?
- Recommendation quality: Is the funding recommendation specific, defensible, and grounded in the evidence appraised?
- Lessons learned: Are the identified lessons actionable and insightful rather than generic?
- Oral defense: Does the team respond to questions with clarity and intellectual honesty?

Reaction Papers — Part of Homework & Reaction Paper Grade (20%)

Six reaction papers are assigned across the semester, one per unit or major topic. Each paper is 1.5–2 pages. The lowest 25% of your reaction paper and homework grades are dropped.

A reaction paper is not a summary. It is a brief analytical response to the assigned reading. A strong reaction paper does one or more of the following: identifies an assumption in the reading that deserves scrutiny; connects the reading to a case from outside the course; challenges a claim with counter-evidence; or explains why a methodological choice the authors made is stronger or weaker than they acknowledge. Papers that summarize the reading without adding analytical judgment will receive minimal credit.

Assessment and Grading

Assessment	Weight	What Is Being Evaluated
Participation	10%	Quality of contributions in discussions, case analyses, and in-class exercises. One incisive observation is worth more than three that restate the obvious.
Reaction Papers & Homework	20%	Brief (1.5–2 page) written responses to assigned readings and short homework tasks. Lowest 25% dropped. Evaluated on analytical engagement, not summary: what is strong, missing, or contestable in this reading?
Project 1: Evaluation Design (RFP Response)	25%	Written proposal designing a program evaluation in response to a real RFP. Evaluated on problem framing, theory of

		change, design justification, methods choice, and professional presentation.
Project 2: Evaluation as Decision Tool	20%	Critique of completed program evaluations with funding recommendations. Evaluated on quality of evidence appraisal, rigor of critique, defensibility of recommendations, and lessons identified for future evaluations.
Program Evaluation in the News (Team)	5%	Team selects, presents, and leads a brief discussion of a real-world evaluation finding or controversy in the news. Evaluated on selection relevance, framing, and quality of discussion questions posed.
Midterm Exam	10%	Short analytical questions on Units 1–3. No fill-in-the-blank. Answers must demonstrate understanding, not recall. One sheet of notes permitted.
Final Exam	10%	Cumulative. Two analytical response questions applying evaluation concepts to a novel program scenario not seen in class. Open note. Recall alone cannot answer these questions.

Grading follows the university's standard grading policy. Late submissions are penalized 10% per day unless an extension is requested at least 48 hours in advance. There is no extra credit. The lowest 25% of reaction papers and homework grades are dropped automatically.

Course Materials

The primary text is Rossi, Lipsey, and Freeman, Evaluation: A Systematic Approach (7th ed., Sage, 2004). Additional methods readings draw from Fowler on survey research and Henry on practical sampling. All readings are available on the course website. Students should complete readings before class. Class discussion and case analyses assume familiarity with the material.

Course Schedule

Week	Session	Topic & In-Class Activities	Assessment / Milestone
UNIT 1 — What Is Program Evaluation and Why Does It Matter? (Weeks 1–2)			
1	1	Course introduction. Central provocation: programs designed to help people sometimes harm them, and we often do not know the difference. What is program evaluation, and why is the answer to that question never purely technical? Overview of the evaluation ecosystem: funders, evaluators, program staff, and target populations. Whose interests align, whose conflict?	**Teams assigned (4–5 students). RFP options distributed for Project 1.**

2	2	The politics and ethics of evidence. When evaluation findings are inconvenient for funders, what happens? Case discussion: a real-world evaluation whose results were suppressed or ignored. What are the evaluator's obligations? Reaction Paper 1 due.	**Reaction Paper 1 is due (end of Week 2) — covers Unit 1 concepts and vocabulary.**
UNIT 2 — Framing the Evaluation: Needs, Theory, and Logic (Weeks 3–5)			
3	3	Stage 0: Context and question formulation. Who commissions evaluations and why? Identifying stakeholders, specifying evaluation questions, and understanding the difference between summative and formative evaluation. In-class exercise: teams map the stakeholders of their Project 1 program.	**Teams select Project 1 RFP and submit one-paragraph rationale.**
4	4	Stage 1: Needs assessment. How do we establish that a problem exists and is large enough to warrant intervention? Probability sampling: random selection and why it matters. Methods focus: designing a needs assessment for a real program. Reaction Paper 2 due.	**Reaction paper 2 is due.**
5	5	Stage 2: Program theory evaluation. What is a logic model and why does every evaluation need one? Unpacking the theory of change: inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes, impact. Methods focus: building a logic model from a vague program description. Teams draft logic model for their Project 1 program.	**Project 1 logic model draft due. Instructor feedback returned within one week.**
UNIT 3 — Process and Implementation: Is the Program Running as Designed? (Weeks 6–7)			
6	6	Stage 3: Process evaluation. How do we assess whether a program is reaching its intended population and being implemented as designed? Coverage, bias, and fidelity. Methods focus: direct observation and document review. Case: a program with strong theory but poor implementation. What went wrong?	**Reaction Paper 3 due.**
7	7	Qualitative methods in evaluation: focus groups and individual interviews. When is qualitative data essential rather than supplementary? In-class exercise: design a focus group protocol for a program serving a vulnerable population. What ethical obligations apply?	**MIDTERM EXAM (end of Week 7). Short analytical questions on Units 1–3. One sheet of notes permitted.**
UNIT 4 — Outcome Evaluation: Does the Program Work? (Weeks 8–11)			
8	8	Identifying and measuring outcomes. What counts as evidence of program success? Reliability, validity, and the gap between what we can measure and what we actually care about. Methods focus: designing survey questions that measure outcomes rather than outputs. Reaction Paper 4 due.	**PROJECT 2 ASSIGNED. Teams receive completed evaluations for critique.**
9	9	The fundamental problem of causal inference. Why can we not simply compare participants to non-participants? Missing counterfactuals, selection bias, and the logic of experimental design. Methods focus: randomized	

		controlled trials — when they are feasible, when they are not, and when they are unethical.	
10	10	Non-experimental and quasi-experimental designs. Regression discontinuity, difference-in-differences, instrumental variables, and matching. For each: what assumption does the design rest on, and when is that assumption plausible? Case: students evaluate the design choices in their Project 2 evaluations.	**Reaction Paper 5 due.**
11	11	Probability sampling II: stratification, clustering, and sample size calculations. How does sampling design affect what an evaluation can and cannot claim? Methods focus: calculate the required sample size for a realistic evaluation scenario.	**PROJECT 1 WRITTEN REPORT DUE (end of Week 11). Feedback returned within one week.**
UNIT 5 — Using Evidence: Interpretation, Communication, and Consequences (Weeks 12–15)			
12	12	Interpreting and presenting evaluation evidence. The difference between statistical significance and practical significance. Over- and under-stating findings. Multiple testing problems and corrections. Case: a published evaluation: what does it actually show, and what have journalists claimed it shows?	**Reaction Paper 6 due.**
13	13	Evaluation in context: low-income and developing country settings. Do evaluation methods developed in high-income contexts travel?	
14	14	PROJECT 2 PRESENTATIONS. Teams present evaluation critiques and funding recommendations (13–15 minutes each). Open questions from class and instructor. Teams are evaluated on the quality of their critique and the defensibility of their recommendations under questioning.	**PROJECT 2 WRITTEN REPORT DUE (end of Week 14).**
15	15	Synthesis and course debrief. What can you now do, argue, and decide that you could not in Week 1? Remaining Program Evaluation in the News presentations. Looking forward: evaluation careers, ethical responsibilities, and the limits of evidence in political environments.	**FINAL EXAM (take-home, 48 hours). Two analytical questions — novel program scenario, open note.**

Required Readings

Full citations and access links are posted on the course website. Additional case study materials will be distributed in class.

Unit 1: What Is Program Evaluation and Why Does It Matter?

- Rossi, Lipsey & Freeman (2004). Evaluation: A Systematic Approach, Chs. 1, 2 & 3.
- Weiss, C.H. (1998). Have We Learned Anything New About the Use of Evaluation? American Journal of Evaluation, 19(1): 21–33. On the politics of evaluation use.

- Selected case: a real-world evaluation whose findings were suppressed or ignored (distributed in class).

Unit 2: Framing the Evaluation — Needs, Theory, and Logic

- Rossi et al. (2004). Chs. 4 & 5 — needs assessment and program theory.
- Henry, G.T. (1990). Practical Sampling, Chs. 1–3 & 6a.
- W.K. Kellogg Foundation (2004). Logic Model Development Guide: practical guide to constructing a theory of change.

Unit 3: Process Evaluation — Is the Program Running as Designed?

- Rossi et al. (2004). Ch. 6: process evaluation.
- Patton, M.Q. (2002). Qualitative Research and Evaluation Methods, Chs. 5,5 (excerpts): focus groups and interviews in evaluation.

Unit 4: Outcome Evaluation — Does the Program Work?

- Rossi et al. (2004). Chs. 7, 8 & 9: outcome measurement, randomized experiments, and non-randomized designs.
- Fowler, F.J. (2002). Survey Research Methods, Chs. 4, 5 & 6: survey design and modes.
- Henry, G.T. (1990). Practical Sampling, Chs. 6b & 7a.

Unit 5: Using Evidence — Interpretation, Communication, and Consequences

- Rossi et al. (2004). Ch. 10: communicating and using evaluation findings.
- Mullainathan, S. & Shafir, E. (2013). Scarcity: Why Having Too Little Means So Much, Ch. 1: cognitive load, poverty, and program design.
- Glennerster, R. & Takavarasha, K. (2013). Running Randomized Evaluations, Ch. 10: on ethics and equity in evaluation design.

Course Policies

Academic Integrity

All work submitted must be your own. Plagiarism and unauthorized collaboration. You are responsible for every sentence you submit. Suspected violations will be referred to the university and may result in a grade of zero or an F in the course.

Attendance and Participation

Regular attendance is expected. Participation is graded on quality, not quantity. One precise, well-reasoned observation is worth more than several that restate what the reading already said. More than two unexcused absences will reduce your participation grade. If you must miss a class, notify the instructor in advance. You are responsible for all material covered whether present or absent.

Extensions and Late Work

Extensions must be requested at least 48 hours before the due date. Requests made after the deadline will not be granted except in documented emergencies. Late work without an approved extension is penalized 10% per day. There is no extra credit.